

Top 30 Fishing Spots Around Columbus, Ohio

Thirty places to wet a line within an easy drive of Columbus. Bring a valid **Ohio fishing license** (and any required stamps), then use the local tip at each spot for parking, nearby food, and what to do if the fish aren't cooperating.

Before you go

- ☐ Current Ohio fishing license (ODNR) — phone download counts if accepted; bring backup ID
- ☐ Know statewide size/bag limits for what you're targeting (they change — check ODNR before you keep fish)
- ☐ Rod + reel you trust, spare hooks/soft plastics, needle-nose pliers
- ☐ Landing net for bigger water
- ☐ Sunscreen, water, bug spray (summer), warm layers (shoulder seasons)
- ☐ Trash bag — pack out what you pack in
- ☐ Optional: small cooler, folding chair, polarized sunglasses

License note: This guide assumes you already have (or will get) a legal Ohio license. It is not a substitute for ODNR regulations.

How to use: Circle 2–3 spots near each other, pick a half-day window, and leave if pressure or weather turns.

Reservoirs & big water

1. Hoover Reservoir — Westerville / NE Columbus

Go for: Crappie, bass, catfish, and shoreline casting with room to roam.

Local tip: Multiple access points — pick one arm and fish it well instead of driving the whole lake. Westerville has coffee and quick food 10 minutes from most ramps.

Nearby: Blendon Woods / Inniswood if the bite dies and you want a short walk.

2. Alum Creek Lake — Lewis Center / Delaware County

Go for: Bass, saugeye, and boat or bank fishing on a big Corps reservoir.

Local tip: Weekday mornings beat weekend jet-ski traffic. Confirm which lots and ramps are open seasonally.

Nearby: Lewis Center / Polaris corridor for food after you load the truck.

3. Griggs Reservoir — NW Columbus (Upper Arlington / Hilliard edge)

Go for: Urban reservoir fishing without leaving the city.

Local tip: Watch for kayakers and cyclists on shared paths; keep gear tidy near the water.

Nearby: Riverside parks and UA/Hilliard lunch spots along Fishinger / Trabue corridors.

4. O'Shaughnessy Reservoir — Dublin / NW

Go for: Bass and panfish with scenic Scioto corridor views.

Local tip: Wind can push hard down the lake — fish the protected pockets when it's gusty.

Nearby: Dublin Bridge Park / Historic Dublin for a post-fish walk and coffee.

5. Buckeye Lake — SE of Columbus (fair day-trip)

Go for: Classic central Ohio lake fishing with lots of shoreline variety.

Local tip: Summer weekends get crowded — dawn or weekday if you can. Confirm public access vs private docks.

Nearby: Small-town food around the lake communities; don't count on every dock being public.

6. Delaware Lake — Delaware State Park (north)

Go for: A quieter reservoir day than Alum Creek on some weekdays.

Local tip: Pair fishing with a park picnic; check state park launch fees/hours.

Nearby: Delaware downtown for a sit-down meal on the way home.

7. Deer Creek Lake — Deer Creek State Park (SW day-trip)

Go for: Bigger-water feel without driving to Lake Erie.

Local tip: Plan it as a half-day or full day — it's farther than metro ponds. Gas up before you leave Columbus.

Nearby: Park camp/picnic areas; limited "city" food nearby so pack snacks.

8. Madison Lake — Madison Lake State Park (SW)

Go for: Smaller state-park lake that's easier to read than huge reservoirs.

Local tip: Great "teach a friend to cast" water — less overwhelming than Hoover.

Nearby: Pack a cooler; amenities are park-basic.

Metro Parks lakes & ponds

9. Sharon Woods Metro Park — lake loop

Go for: Convenient NE Columbus fishing with easy parking.

Local tip: Share the shore with walkers — keep casts away from the path. Early morning is calmer.

Nearby: Park restrooms + Westerville food after.

10. Antrim Park — Worthington

Go for: Quick after-work casts on a neighborhood lake.

Local tip: Geese and foot traffic are part of the deal; travel light.

Nearby: Worthington / High Street bites within a few minutes.

11. Rocky Fork Metro Park — lake / shoreline

Go for: Metro Park water with room to try a few banks.

Local tip: Check park rules for fishing zones and any seasonal closures.

Nearby: Gahanna / New Albany corridors for food.

12. Pickerington Ponds Metro Park

Go for: Wetland ponds and bird-heavy quiet — fishing plus binoculars.

Local tip: Soft banks after rain; wear shoes you don't mind muddy.

Nearby: Pickerington for groceries/snacks on the way out.

13. Glacier Ridge Metro Park — ponds / open water edges

Go for: Northwest metro fishing when you want sky and fewer downtown vibes.

Local tip: Little shade — summer heat is real; bring water.

Nearby: Dublin / Plain City direction for food depending which entrance you use.

14. Prairie Oaks Metro Park — Big Darby corridor

Go for: Creek/river energy inside the metro system (check posted fishing rules).

Local tip: Current and clarity change after storms — wait a day if it's chocolate milk.

Nearby: West-side / Hilliard food; enjoy the prairie walk if fishing slows.

15. Battelle Darby Creek Metro Park

Go for: Creek fishing and prairie backdrop — different pace than reservoirs.

Local tip: Stay out of restricted/sensitive zones; fish only where posted as allowed.

Nearby: Nature center area for orientation; pack lunch.

16. Three Creeks Metro Park — confluence water

Go for: Urban creek junctions with surprising wildlife.

Local tip: After heavy rain, currents spike — safety first, ego second.

Nearby: South/east Columbus food corridors; easy "I'll just fish 90 minutes" stop.

17. Blacklick Woods Metro Park — ponds/creek edges

Go for: Forest-feel fishing close to Reynoldsburg / east side.

Local tip: Roots and mud — grip shoes beat flip-flops.

Nearby: East-side fast casual on Brice / Main corridors.

18. Scioto Audubon Metro Park — downtown-adjacent water

Go for: Skyline fishing energy (follow all posted rules).

Local tip: Great for "I only have an hour after work" — park once, travel light.

Nearby: Brewery District / German Village bites after you rinse your hands.

19. Homestead Park — Hilliard (pond)

Go for: Family-friendly local pond fishing.

Local tip: Ideal for kids' first bluegill day; keep expectations small and fun.

Nearby: Hilliard Rome / Old Hilliard food.

20. Darby Creek / park access points (metro west)

Go for: Moving water when lakes feel stagnant.

Local tip: Respect private property — use official park access only.

Nearby: Combine with a short prairie trail if the bite is slow.

Rivers & creeks (public access only)

21. Scioto River — Griggs to downtown corridor

Go for: Urban river fishing with multiple public parks as base camps.

Local tip: Pick one park access (don't hop fences). Summer evenings can be excellent.

Nearby: Grandview / Franklinton / downtown food depending where you exit.

22. Scioto River — south of downtown (public parks)

Go for: Slightly less polished banks for anglers who want space.

Local tip: Watch footing on riprap; tell someone your plan.

Nearby: South Side / German Village for a victory meal.

23. Olentangy River — Worthington / Clintonville access

Go for: North-side river fishing near neighborhoods you already know.

Local tip: Bike path traffic is high — cast with awareness.

Nearby: Clintonville coffee and casual food on High Street.

24. Olentangy River — north toward Delaware County public spots

Go for: Stretching upstream when Columbus banks feel pressured.

Local tip: Confirm each lot is public; river corridors mix park and private land.

Nearby: Powell / Delaware food options on the drive.

25. Big Walnut Creek — east/southeast public parks

Go for: Creek fishing with less “reservoir crowd” energy.

Local tip: After storms, wait for safer levels and clearer water.

Nearby: Gahanna / Reynoldsburg / Canal Winchester depending on which stretch.

26. Alum Creek — below-dam / creek sections (public only)

Go for: Moving water variety when the lake is blown out by wind.

Local tip: Dam areas can have special rules and dangerous current — read signs.

Nearby: Westerville / Lewis Center for supplies.

27. Blacklick Creek — east-side park access

Go for: Local creek casting without a long drive.

Local tip: Small water = light tackle and patience.

Nearby: East Columbus shopping corridors for last-minute bait/snacks.

Easy day-trip & “worth the drive” options

28. A.W. Marion State Park — Circleville area

Go for: Compact state-park lake south of town.

Local tip: Treat it as a half-day outing; check park hours before you leave.

Nearby: Circleville for a simple meal on the way back.

29. Slate Run Metro Park — ponds & quiet park time

Go for: Southeast metro outing that feels farther than it is.

Local tip: Confirm fishing-allowed water vs wildlife-only ponds before you cast.

Nearby: Park trails and farm-area scenery if you switch to walking mode.

30. Chestnut Ridge Metro Park — perched water / park edges

Go for: A change-of-scenery metro stop with fishing potential where posted.

Local tip: Combine with a short ridge walk so the day isn't only “wait for a bite.”

Nearby: Southeast suburbs for gas and food before you return north.

Half-day sampler menus

NE Columbus loop: Hoover → Sharon Woods → Westerville food
NW metro loop: Griggs or O'Shaughnessy → Dublin coffee → short Bridge Park walk
East side loop: Rocky Fork or Pickerington Ponds → Gahanna/Pickerington bite
Teach-a-kid day: Homestead Park or Madison Lake → pack snacks → quit while it's still fun
Day-trip: Deer Creek or Delaware Lake — leave early, home by dinner

Gear & bait quick list

- ☐ License + ID
 - ☐ Rod/reel + spare spool or line
 - ☐ Hooks, sinkers, bobbers, soft plastics, nightcrawlers (as allowed)
 - ☐ Pliers / line clippers
 - ☐ Net
 - ☐ Measuring device (if keeping fish)
 - ☐ Cooler + ice (if keeping)
 - ☐ Headlamp for dawn/dusk
 - ☐ First-aid basics
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Trip log (fill in)

Date	Spot # / name	Hours	Caught?	Keep / release	Notes

Favorite of the 30: _____
Best local food after fishing: _____
Next spot to try: _____

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